## Submission to the Inquiry into the 2025 Federal Election in Australia

In my local electorate of Wannon, there was a huge campaign of misinformation and disinformation that began well before any election announcement. In my opinion, content that would be illegal once the election is announced should also not be allowed to be published before the election announcement—for the same reasons it is not permitted once the election has been called.

In the lead-up to the election, Wannon was saturated with flyers and advertising, much of which was propaganda. People were already 'over' the election before it had even been announced, due to the overwhelming amount of advertising material they had received. As a result, voters often didn't pay attention to information they received once the election was officially underway, having already been inundated. The misinformation and disinformation therefore played a role in shaping their understanding of the election. For this reason, rules around political advertising and information should apply at all times—not just in the final period before an election.

Democracy should surely be based on informed decision-making.
There is no place in democracy for lies.

Another issue I am concerned about is that the general public does not seem to know that materials published by the AEC are not necessarily factual. People tend to believe anything issued by the AEC must be true. They are often unaware that the AEC receives statements from each candidate (or, in the case of the Voice referendum, from each 'side') and publishes them as submitted, without fact-checking. The fact that the AEC, for the first time, publicly stated this and encouraged people to do their own fact-checking during the most recent federal election highlights that this is a real issue.

Again, democracy should be about informed decision-making. You cannot make an informed decision without truthful information. In my opinion, the AEC should be given a mandate to fact-check all information provided to them by political parties and to publish only factual information. At the very least, the law should be amended so that all statements from politicians or political parties on AEC documentation are clearly labelled as opinion, rather than being presented in wording that makes them appear to be factual.

I believe legislative reform to mandate truth in political advertising must occur, and could be based on the South Australian legislation.

https://australiainstitute.org.au/post/truth-in-political-advertising-laws/

I believe the misinformation and disinformation circulated during the campaign contributed to the aggressive and disruptive behaviours that occurred in Wannon.

During the recent federal election, I witnessed a large online (and offline) campaign targeting our local independent candidate in Wannon, [redacted]. On numerous social media pages, the same names appeared repeatedly, making derogatory comments and citing false information about [redacted] and his campaign. I questioned whether these frequent commenters were real people or AI bots. They often responded immediately to any new

post—for example, on [redacted] campaign Facebook page or on the [redacted] Facebook page (a local news page in SW Victoria, that is unmoderated).

There seemed to be a coordinated campaign against [redacted], with the following themes:

**1. Personal attacks**
These included attacks on his integrity, name-calling, and the use of expletives. Old photos and footage from [redacted] were widely circulated, with the implication that he actually held the views expressed in those [redacted] and would act on them if elected. None of this was based in fact. It involved the misuse of old images, taken out of context, and attempted to present [redacted] quotes as real-life policy statements. This practice should not be permitted. Election advertising should be factual, truthful, or clearly labelled as opinion only.

Advance funded many flyers that used this approach, and both the [redacted] and Advance produced flyers falsely suggesting that [redacted] was a member of the [redacted]

**2. Anti-renewable energy messaging**
In particular, there was heavy circulation of anti-offshore wind farm propaganda. The Facebook group [redacted] had the same administrator as the group [redacted] (which seems to have disappeared from Facebook since the election). The main organiser was [redacted], a former [redacted] party member. Around Wannon, it was common to see [redacted] signs placed alongside [redacted] signs.

This group was not interested in engaging with the public on the science behind offshore wind farms. I attempted to interact on their page and provided up-to-date information and references, but in response, I received only outdated sources. They refused to engage in meaningful discussion about the science.

I believe the *No Offshore Wind Farms* group aimed to support [redacted] re-election and was more broadly anti-renewable energy than genuinely concerned about environmental issues.

I also believe there are links between Advance Australia, the Atlas "think tank" organisation, and anti-offshore wind farm groups globally. These groups serve the agenda of mining and fossil fuel companies. These connections are often not visible and can be difficult to trace. There should be greater transparency about who is funding political advertising and information campaigns, and any conflicts of interest should be publicly declared.

Advance spokesperson [redacted] is active in dozens of local Facebook groups opposing renewable projects in places such as Lake Borumba and Mount Fox in Queensland, where she regularly shares Advance content. She was in the Facebook group [redacted] during the election campaign.

Advance's heavy spending underscores the growing use of proxy organisations to conduct campaigns that major political parties wish to distance themselves from. The third-party status of these groups allows politicians to maintain plausible deniability despite close political affiliations.

Advance received $500,000 from the Cormack Foundation in 2023–2024. The Cormack Foundation is a nominated entity for the [redacted] under state electoral laws, meaning it ostensibly exists for the "principal benefit" of the party's members. The *Australian Financial Review* reported in February that this large donation to Advance was the subject of a complaint to the Victorian Electoral Commission, due to concerns it breached the "principal benefit" requirement. The [redacted] stated it was unaware of the donation.

Recent changes to political donation laws have not resolved the core problem that wealthy groups can fund massive advertising campaigns to influence elections. In fact, the new laws will likely increase inequity, leaving smaller parties and independent candidates at a significant disadvantage. This is detrimental to democracy. There should be equity in the amount of money that each candidate can spend on political advertising.

**References include:**

[redacted]

The interference of 'big money' and organisations like those mentioned should not be allowed to influence Australia's democracy. Unless media, political donation, and advertising laws are changed, this will continue—and our democracy will continue to deteriorate.

Again, I say: democracy can only be based on informed choice.
To be truly informed, people must be able to distinguish between factual information and falsehoods. Anything that makes this difficult should not be allowed in election campaigns.

Another concern I have about the recent federal election is the involvement of the Exclusive Brethren. It appears that the church leadership instructed its members to support [redacted] candidates. This is not free choice by individuals volunteering for political candidates—it is coercion, and it should not be allowed. It is especially concerning given the context: this is a religious group that does not believe in voting. In Wannon, Brethren members were handing out how-to-vote cards at pre-poll centres.

**Regarding the functioning of Parliament**, I support the recommendations outlined in the report *Opportunities to Improve the Operation and Effectiveness of the Federal Parliament* (Susan McKinnon Foundation, 14 April 2025).
https://apo.org.au/sites/default/files/resource-files/2025-04/apo-nid330313.pdf

However, one area not addressed in this report is the need for greater transparency in relation to lobbying activities in Federal Parliament. As of July 2025, approximately 360

organisations and more than 700 individuals were registered as lobbyists, representing around 2,400 clients. A concerning trend is the increasing dominance of former government representatives within this group—with over 40% of registered lobbyists being former ministers or staffers.

The current system does not require all lobbyists operating in Parliament to be registered, meaning the official register is incomplete. Lobbyists often have significantly more access to politicians, Ministers, and senior government officials than the general public. This imbalance in access undermines transparency and skews influence in favour of corporate interests over the broader public good.

In my view, this is not how a healthy democracy should function. Lobbyist influence significantly distorts both the electoral process and broader parliamentary decision-making. I strongly support the need for substantial reform in this area and endorse the recommendations proposed by Senator David Pocock, as outlined in the Parliamentary Business Committee reference below.

**References**:

• https://australiainstitute.org.au/wp-content/uploads/2024/12/P1650-Trade-associations-The-Australian-picture-Web.pdf
• https://www.aph.gov.au/Parliamentary_Business/Committees/Senate/Finance_and_Public_Administration/LobbyistsAccessAPH47/Report/Dissenting_report_from_Senator_David_Pocock
• https://www.theguardian.com/australia-news/2025/jul/26/lobbyist-breaches-go-unsanctioned-as-critics-call-for-federal-regime-to-be-strengthened-ntwnfb
• https://grattan.edu.au/wp-content/uploads/2018/09/908-Who-s-in-the-room-Access-and-influence-in-Australian-politics.pdf

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**Finally**, I would like to address the issue of representation in Parliament, particularly in relation to the number of elected representatives per population.

Wannon is a vast electorate—geographically equivalent in size to Belgium—and encompasses highly diverse population groups. These include a substantial inland farming and primary production community, as well as more urban populations concentrated along the coast. It is simply not feasible for a single representative to effectively reflect the distinct political perspectives and needs of such varied communities.

Given how close the recent election result was in Wannon, it is clear that the current member does not represent the views of nearly 50% of the electorate. Yet, achieving change in representation remains extremely difficult. Many constituents have lost hope that their voices will ever be adequately represented in Parliament.

These geographic and demographic challenges must be considered by the inquiry when assessing the appropriate ratio of elected representatives to population.